NEAPOLITAN-STYLE PIZZA IN A HOME OVEN

MAKES	ACTIVE TIME	OVEN	ENERGY COST
3 pizzas	**15 min**	**maximum, around 250C or 480F, top and bottom heat, 45 min preheat**	**$2.27 (45 min preheat plus 21 min baking for three pizzas, 3.5 kW at 59 cents/kWh)**

INGREDIENTS

3 balls of 260 g	Pizza dough
2 1/2 tsp per pizza	Tomato passata
quantity not given	Fresh mozzarella, well drained
quantity not given	Pepperoni
quantity not given	Fresh basil
quantity not given	Parmigiano-reggiano, grated
quantity not given	Semolina, for dusting
quantity not given	Salt
quantity not given	Olive oil

METHOD

1. Turn an oven tray upside down so you have a flat surface to launch from, and set the oven to its maximum with heat top and bottom. Leave the tray in there at least 45 minutes.
2. Drain the mozzarella while the oven heats. It gives up a surprising amount of water, and that water ends up on the pizza otherwise.
3. Dust a ball generously with semolina and open it out on the bench, pressing from the centre with your fingertips held perpendicular to the dough. It is extensible enough to give easily, so work gently.
4. Move it onto a peel, or onto a piece of stiff cardboard if you have no peel, and shake the loose semolina off.
5. Spread about two and a half teaspoons of passata and no more, then a pinch of salt and a little oil. Nothing else goes on yet.
6. Slide it onto the hot tray and bake around 4 minutes. The base wants to be cooked but not coloured. Lift an edge at 3 minutes and pull it while it is still soft enough to bend.
7. Lay the basil, the drained mozzarella and the pepperoni over the part-baked base.
8. Send it back for 2 to 3 minutes, 4 at the outside. If your oven has a grill, this is the stage to use it, to finish the top.
9. Off the tray, finish with grated parmigiano and a last drizzle of olive oil.

NOTES

Splitting the bake is the whole trick. One continuous bake in a home oven dries the base to a cracker before the top is anywhere near done, so the base goes in nearly bare and the toppings get a short second pass.
Pull the first bake while the base still bends. That is what leaves the finished pizza soft instead of hard.
The tray goes in upside down for a flat launch surface. The right way up it has a lip and a dip, and sliding a wet pizza off a peel onto that is awkward.
No stone and no steel here. The preheated tray is all the thermal mass there is, which is why it needs the full 45 minutes rather than the 10 a stone would want.
Keep the passata sparing, and every topping in its own measure rather than piled on. A wet pizza will not set in a home oven.
A home oven stops around 250C against the 450C-plus a Neapolitan base is built for. Everything odd about this recipe, the high hydration, the sugar, the oil, the two bakes, exists to work around that ceiling.

LEARNINGS

- 5 out of 5 as home pizza, which is the bar it should be judged against. A 250C oven cannot char a rim the way a wood fire does, so the question is whether this is as good as a home oven gets, and it is. The highest grade in the collection so far.
- The split bake is what earns the score. Everything that usually goes wrong with pizza in a domestic oven comes from one long bake, and this sidesteps it.
- Keep the second bake short. The base is already cooked when it goes back in, so the only job left is colour.

DOUGH

High-Hydration Pizza Dough for a Home Oven

Makes: 3 balls of 260 g / Active Time: 20 min across the folds / Rest: 12 h cold, then a few hours at room temperature

INGREDIENTS

230 g	All-purpose flour
230 g	Bread flour
330 g	Water
15 g	Extra-virgin olive oil
8 g	Salt
5 g	Sugar
0.5 g	Fresh yeast

METHOD

1. Stir the two flours together with the sugar.
2. Dissolve the yeast in the water, then pour that over the flour along with the oil and the salt.
3. Squeeze everything through your hands for about 30 seconds, until no dry flour is left. It will be slack and it will stick. Cover and leave 15 to 20 minutes.
4. First round of folds: wet your hands, run them down the inside of the bowl to release the dough, lift it, let it drop and fold it under itself. Turn the bowl a quarter and repeat until the ball will not take another fold. Cover, 15 minutes.
5. Second round, the same way. Keep going in 15-minute rounds, three or four of them if that is what it takes, until the surface is smooth and the ball has spread too wide and relaxed to fold again.
6. Cover and refrigerate 12 hours, overnight.
7. Turn the cold dough onto a lightly damp bench and divide into three balls of about 260 g.
8. Leave them at room temperature until they have grown, gone airy and slumped a little. Judge this by eye, not by the clock, because it depends entirely on how warm your kitchen is.

NOTES

330 g of water against 460 g of flour is 72% hydration, well above the 62 to 63% of a classic Neapolitan dough. The extra water is there because a home oven needs about six minutes rather than ninety seconds, and a drier dough comes out of that bake like a rock.

The two flours do different jobs. Bread flour carries the long ferment and supplies elasticity, all-purpose keeps the dough extensible so it stretches without fighting back. Both are ordinary supermarket flours, nothing specialist.

Sugar and olive oil are both departures from a classic Neapolitan dough. The sugar browns a rim in an oven that cannot char it, the oil buys extensibility.

If the dough stays lumpy and soupy and never comes smooth, your flour will not carry this much water. Drop 40 to 50 g of it and keep everything else the same.

0.5 g of fresh yeast is a piece about the size of a dried chickpea. Dry yeast is far stronger, so barely the tip of a spoon.

There is no mixer in this. All the structure comes from the folds and the rests.

Balls that never grow mean the yeast was dead, or the kitchen is cold enough that this little yeast cannot do the job.

DATE ____ / ____ / ____ RATING ____ / 5 OVEN ADJ _____

NOTES _____

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